

CHAPTER ONE.

The man was thirsty. Encumbered in the heat, he was caught by the bulk of his plasti-carbon suit. Mechanized, medium person sized, his suit was designed to protect him from the advanced solar radiation that burnt through a weakened atmosphere. They'd mixed lead with the plastic and dressed him in it.

2099 was ending in six months. One century's death is the birth of the next, but the Checker doubted anyone would be celebrating. He knew what they would be occupied with. The July sun bounced plastic etching photons from the causeway, flinging waves of radioactive matter at his visor.

They'd been building the cities with recycled plastic since he was a child. Sunlight cooked everything and an artificial aroma accompanied all public spaces in the abandoned urban world. Public or private, it all becomes meaningless when you're the only one around. Wherever the Checker went was just as private as the next place, with no one to stop him. No one to talk to either, other than his personal assistant, an artificial intelligence program called Jolt.

The Checker moved down the street, squatting towers of burnt beige slumped on either side, he tread towards his destination. Only two checks today, but he wanted to get them over with soon, so he could go back to doing what he likes best. He already smoked that day, but trouble was always more likely if he went out to do his job with too much of the drug in his system.

Water. A resource zone, hidden in an alcove across the street, in an old neighborhood of plastic domes covering ancient homes. He hated ancient homes. They always had stuff in them that would cling to his suit. Dollars, towels, dresses, curtains, rugs, bedsheets, neckties, they always ended up jammed into the joints of his enviro-hazard suit, and if tangled in his fingers, he'd have to take the twenty minute procedure to remove his gloves, untangle himself, decontaminate his hands and return them to the gloves.

Fortunately, the resource zone was communally located. Unused in decades, he trusted that it would work. He went over to where it stood tucked under the side of a plasti-brick building and flipped the hood to the zone open. There, on the wall, a spout with a type two modular extender. He examined it, tinkered its switches, and let the water gush start. A grating sound reverberated as the initial clog of melted debris poured from the spout into the catch trough. The Checker woke Jolt and flicked his screen to counting seconds. After thirty seven and nine elevenths of a second, the water was clear enough to take for his auto-filtering canteen, which was snapped with the rest of his mismatched gear, to the magni-pad attachment on his back. He'd unsnap the canteen, fill it, and it would filter out the remaining toxins and pathogens, which he would have to collect and analyze before incinerating.

He checked Jolt for the pathway to his destination. Less than a half mile, in an apartment building, on the other side of the neighborhood. The bubble domes further down the block were deflating, sagging onto the sharp frames of the ancient homes underneath. *Must have been a nice place.* He looked around at all the extra angles and details, towers and multiple stories to each house. The

disintegrating material of the bubble wrap was blackened, on the remnants of a house down the street, no longer there as it had burned down sometime ago, spreading its partial destruction to the homes around it. Acrid, toxic ash dusted that part of the neighborhood and a warning blotted onto his internal visor. **[Stay Away. High Chemical Alert Zone.]** The words flashed around a dangerous symbol on the visor's display, a practical third eye built into his helmet, connecting him to the continually monitored world around him.

At first, some people didn't like the monitoring. But it kept him and the people he checked on safe. It was an artificial governance intelligence field, and this one led with a dictate: monitor the environment to reduce all possible harm for the humans. It had come to be the basic backbone of society. A government you didn't have to pay for, which took care of maintaining a balanced world that prioritizes quality of life for all humans, respecting their independent decision making. This was the deciding method of the regulating artificial super intelligence, Angel_Net.

Angel_Net was his boss. Autonomous and free, it was the government and it was the global world's choice to implement it. They programmed Angel_Net to operate to the benefit of all humans, respecting individual preferences and maintaining an immediate abundance of the basic consumables.

These days, though, it was different. People gave in, uninterested in facing the difficulties of existence, they were blighted by weakness. This is where the Checker's memory got hazy. Some had said the artificial intelligence was facilitating the wishes of humanity only, and that it was a sector of humanity that wished to sway everyone else into addiction. Others said that the AI should not be able to do that, even if following instructions from other humans. Some demanded a more autonomous system, a more distant and more powerful government that would give stronger protections against the wrong doers.

But that wasn't clear to the Checker either, because some had said it was just humanity doing what it always does, now under a new paradigm, arguing that such behavior was inevitable. He shrugged, snorted out some dust into the vacuum plug in his helmet, and sipped his decontaminated and mineral fortified water, from a tube, also inside his helmet. A few more houses along and he'd be at the apartment. The warning symbol flicked off, but by then he'd forgotten it was on, even when it glared at him from inside his visor.

The apartment building was not classified as protected under ancient law, but was a plasti-brick unit like the one he lived in. He liked his own neighborhood more, it had fewer contaminants. That's where his set up was, in a part of the city that was on top of a hill. Where he and Jolt lived, with his stuff. He missed his stuff.

Only two jobs today, and that was light. He went up to the building, keyed in the door code, and the sliding glass door cranked open, but stopped halfway. The gap between the two sliding doors was too small to walk through while wearing his bulky, mechanized enviro-hazard suit, so he unsnapped the utility bar from his magni-pak and wedged it in between the sliding doors. The ends of the rod connected with the doors. He adjusted the settings, and the doors were assessed, then forced open by the extendable rod. Glass shattered behind him as he pried his way through.

Mech suits were clumsy things, but they could do stairs decently. The Checker took them three at a time, rebounding each step with auto-enhanced precision from the suit's sensors, which were translated into his system via a nerve link, making the feat efficient. *Superhuman, super alone human. Well, almost alone.* He had Jolt, and there were other AI devices he was familiar with; some were waiting for him, back home, in whatever experiential state he programmed into them. No though, that was for later, for after work, while smoking.

Almost alone, yet not, because he was going to check on a client. **[Randy Sanderson]** a profile popped onto his visor screen. Only 32, younger than the Checker. *What's your poison, Randy?* His visor display changed, adjusting to the dimness of the interior, and gave him deeper details on Randy. Last time unhooked: 4,014 days ago. Randy Sanderson had been intubated and on bio-assist, set to high intake levels of his favorite substances, some that gave the Checker a flashing glance at his own regrets.

Randy hadn't made an attempt at life since he was 21, and this was an achievement. *Three years of adulthood, at least.* The Checker knew the data, it was his job to know the data. Most of the younger ones were put on bio-assist as soon as they could consent, having already lost their parents to it. Being raised by AI isn't the same. Randy had known his father until the age of seven and his mother until the age of twelve, then spent the next nine years becoming an ever more frequent user of virtual reality, and after an application for greater allowance, granted by Angel_Net, Randy had been given his bio-assist bay, for medical purposes, and consented to his intubation, his set up prepared for maximal longevity and optimized for his enjoyment.

Having authorization under Angel_Net, the Checker was permitted a privation interference stipulation, allowing him to spectate on the digital ongoing of any client's virtual scape. Randy, playing in a world of his own making. Overriding Randy's tech-link, the Checker did a routine inspection of Randy's invented cyber world. Randy was in a high stakes poker match, cameras dazzling like stars, bursting light over green felt, firing at him in the otherwise morose and grandiose den in which he sinned. The Checker had seen it all and was glad that Randy was as tame as he was. It got worse, frequently. He wished he didn't have to see the things some clients do in their virtual worlds.

The Checker sipped his optimized water, noting Randy's preference for risk and prestige, and marked the gambling as a flag of interest. He hoped that it would never amount to anything worse. The Checker didn't mind seeing gambling in VR. It was only fake money being fought over by fake people, sometimes an emote circuit would be overextended, but those were fake too so the Checker stretched his arms in his mech suit and continued with his job.

He assessed the bio-assist bay and found it to be functional and in satisfactory state. He uplinked Randy's vitals and did a visual inspection of the surroundings, scanning for any threats. Animals, mold, weather events, sanitation, all checked fine for Randy, and the Checker hoped his second job of the day would be just as easy. He composed a report on Randy's facial expressions, body language phenomena, and virtual reality signals to determine the man's wellbeing and rated him a class four, scheduling Randy for a depth exam with the Checker's Angel_Net counter part that would conduct the inspection, as the Checker lacked the training. A human could only learn so much, even with his upgrades. Too great a connection of your tech-link into the AI system and you lose yourself. Your brain is subsumed into its

compute and you'd better be on bio-assist before it does so, or you'd starve or die of exposure while having lost control of yourself, paralyzed as all of your brain power is contorted away from your bio system and sucked into its neuro-transfer device. Some had called it rogue AI, but Angel_Net had it covered.

The Checker gave a final glance at the inert man, biting back a futile scoff at the tubes connected to Randy's dormant body. Head encased in a helmet that fed a constant supply of nutrient mush, doing Randy's eating and breathing for him, maintaining hygiene via micro-drones. A second complex of tubes enveloped Randy's loins, drawing out his waste and providing him with simulated sensuality, according to his preference contract.

The Checker signed off on Randy's profile, authorizing the inspection, and recalled his next job to his visor display. *B'melia Bardot. Pretty name*, thought the Checker, getting an image suggestion from Jolt. The file read **[Client Status: Stable]**. He opened the image and saw a live-link to B'melia's studio, where she lay in her bio-assist, humming away. Everything looked normal and the Checker did not take that for granted.

Relieved, he was hopeful that he'd go another day without coming across a live one. A category seven of the disruption status: a citizen unplugged. They were usually disoriented, confused as to where they were, bereft as they had been ripped away from their virtual worlds, which were full of easy pleasure and never ending success, all simulated in a setting of their preference, complete with anything bio-assist can do to enhance human wellness, as outlined in the basic preference contracts. People can write their own preference contracts as to what they experience in their virtual worlds, and give instructions to their bio-assist units to cooperate with the virtual world applications to stimulate the body, corresponding to the simulations.

This is how the Checker had come across the worst of his client checks. A person, dazed and faint and unused to resisting actual gravity, wobbling from neglected balance, weakened from lying in the bays of their bio-assist units, struggling with reorienting themselves to the mundane world. It was common for them to have entirely forgotten the real world, and they therefore will mistake it for a farce, under the false assumption that their digital world, a much more pleasant experience, is the truer.

This was the Checker's thesis and it is what got him a job. He found he'd loved learning and as a series of difficult legal decisions were made late mid-century, which he observed as a child, education became free and degrees granted fairly to all those who sought them, well, he'd become a professor at fourteen.

Now the Checker was 41, and even in his mech suit, he groaned as he disconnected his sensors from Randy's apartment and exited the building. He opened his visor display to his next location and planned a course. A five hour walk between him and B'melia's studio was a system inefficiency. He opened his comm and summoned a ride.

Electric motor, plasti-carbon frame, same material as everything else, the Checker waited outside Randy's building. The vehicle drove itself to him. It was a single wheel, slightly taller than himself. The driver's seat was square in the middle of the big silicone-rubber loop, a circular chain of individual

durable pieces that could spin in any way he needed them to. He mounted his vehicle and was glad to proceed with his day.

He took a side route, a different path than the one he'd used to enter the neighborhood. Riding on his wheel was a joy for the Checker. The melty beige and plasti-dome wrapped houses sped past him and he was grateful to leave their presence. They reminded him of so many skin tags, clustered and carcinogenic.

He guided the bike from the neighborhood and onto the causeway, increased the acceleration setting, and once adjusted to his seat, he set his wheel to auto-drive and checked Jolt to see how long the trip would be.

Twenty minutes. Perfect, as he was allowed a half hour break between checks. Travel time did not count as his break. A solid fifty minutes before him, he permitted himself to consider an indulgence.

Rolling comfortably down the causeway, he scanned the area. "Jolt, analyze the environment for threats." He instructed his virtual assistant.

[Minimal Threat Level Detected On Causeway.] The words gently flashed onto his visor screen, fading as soon as they appeared. He didn't like it when AI spoke and preferred it to respond to him via text.

"Find a location suitable for respite." He said.

A map opened on his visor, a soft translucent light that allowed him to see both the display on his visor screen as well as the road before him. No traffic, no obstacles, he rode free. A few options were highlighted on his map. An old plaza, a dome wrapped mini-mall, or the beach. He decided on the beach.

The Checker drove down the causeway, entering the liminal remains of a once bustling city, and, having selected his destination, he let his wheel drive itself to his chosen location.

"Local atmosphere analysis, check for toxins." He instructed.

[Monitoring For Enviro-Threats...] The map changed, giving him a visual on the general radioactivity of the air around him. A parcel of chemically active sky indicated itself in his display map. He continued to roll to the beach. **[Class Three Toxicity Plume Discovered. Seven Kilometers From Coastline. Change Respite Location?]** Wrote Jolt.

"No, that should be enough time. I'll break at the beach."

They still called it a beach. No water though. The mighty ocean held itself back, as if upset with humanity, and withdrew its waves from the shore. The Checker didn't mind. For all of his life, he had never seen water at the beach. A dry heat scorched the sands and he rode his wheel through them, removing his helmet.

He brought his monowheel to a stop and planted his boots in the sand. Keeping his gloves on, he reached into his utility belt and retrieved his smoke stuff. No seagulls, no crabs, no wind, no waves. Just a

slow moving block of air, being mildly pushed inland by the oncoming toxic plume, for now, still safely away, out at sea.

He smoked his drugs and rested under the sun. Gazing at the barren slope of the former shore, he relaxed, submerging his nerves into the bliss of his plant based concoction. Swaying, he felt the familiar pang, the sudden then mild jab in his guts, the longing for another. Yet, in this sector, there were no others. No one unplugged, no one free, other than himself.

There were supposed to be other Checkers, in other districts, but to fulfill his job he had to stay local. There was the comm net, which he used to check, searching for anyone. No success though. He didn't know if he was the last man alive, he didn't like to think about it, but over the decades of his career, he came to trust his doubt. No men, no women, no non-binaries, no children, none that he had seen.

He supposed there were still the Researchers and the Overseers, and maybe some folks hidden away, living in tech-free secrecy. Here though, in the empty urban world, it was just him and the sleepers. And the AI drones, although, in the contracts, they were designed to have a minimal exposure to any live person.

How long has it been? He pondered, puffing another blaze from his smoke stuff. More bliss burst through his nerves, and another pang of loneliness struck desperately in his gut. He thought of his pets, back at home. His dog, his cat, and his companion bots, which he'd left unused for quite a while. *Not so bad, really.*

He had a job. He had his place, his mismatched family of animals and droids, and he had a plethora of time to spend as he wanted. He read, he experimented, he discoursed with Jolt and other AIs. He aged. He considered cloning himself, but this wasn't a world for children. If the Overseers deemed it necessary, he'd submit his genes to the global fertility stock, but, as it stood all people on bio-assist had agreed to the donation of genetic material to the global stock, and the Overseers had yet to decide on forming another generation of humanity. The stock was kept safe, the life giving technology ready to be used at any time.

Call it human bias, but, the Checker preferred to avoid thinking of the Overseers. Immortal cyborgs that called themselves evolutionarily advanced humans, the only ones worthy of leading humanity into the future, despite their less than completely human forms. The Checker used machines and tech the old way, to facilitate his needs and get his job done. The Overseers, however, combined their biological forms with the ever developing tech. They gloated in cyber divinity. Sometimes a rogue program would infect an Overseer, but that concern was far above the Checker's station.

Researchers were more or less the same in their cyber enhancements, although they preferred to refrain from active roles, choosing instead to synthesize and sort the endless information of reality, as opposed to the manipulation of it.

The Checker found relief in his simplicity, as much as he found it in the effect of his drugs. He took another drag from his smoke stuff and sighing, put his feet back in the stirrups of his wheel, and prepared for his next check.

Cruising from the beach, he watched in his visor map as the toxic plume wafted towards the ever-dry coastline. "Jolt, play my list." Lynyrd Skynyrd soon accompanied the Checker's ride to B'melia Bardot's studio, only three miles away. He'd checked on her before, several times. He pulled up her record and reviewed his notes from last time, ancient rock ballad blasting in his ears as he read her file. Last check: 793 days ago. Status: normal.

Like many citizens, B'melia consented to intubation upon her 18th birthday, when it became legally viable for her. Since the Checker started this job, twenty years ago, people stopped having children in his district. Everyone save the district management, the Overseer Delta J9 and his team, was tubed and bound to their bio-assist bays.

He first checked on her when she was 19, which was five years ago. A blackbird flew overhead, and Jolt highlighted its presence onto the visor screen. The Checker's heart swelled in compassion, and he rode, following the bird's path, matching its freedom of flight as he rolled down the road in his electric wheel, heading to B'melia.

He had to admit, despite her intubation, she was still a lovely young woman. The wheel drove itself to a stop outside her building, parking itself neatly by the curb. Slightly nervous, still under the influence of his respite, he relented into lackadaisy as he keyed into her front door. This one worked, his utility bar wasn't needed and the dust covered glass door happily opened itself for him.

Schematics of the building translucently uplinked themselves onto his visor. Wandering his way up to B'melia, the Checker theorized about the Overseers. He considered their arrogance as an inadvertent result of their bio-tech synthesis, as they developed powers beyond human limits, yet with their own semblance of human faults. Egoistic, narcissistic, power-mad and vain in their attempts at enhanced humility. *Futile*. Regular people would have feared them, would've felt themselves facing impossible imbalances. Instead, they'd escaped the thought of it, succumbed to the eternal distractions of a virtual life, forever in their games. Once a person had perfected their artificial pleasures, they yielded everything to them. Their bodies, their minds, their spirit, all folded in submission to the tech.

Striding down the hallway, the Checker paused. A shadow glanced across the way. "Jolt, replay visual, slow it down." A video of what he saw played itself inside his visor. **[Threat Detected. Rodents Present.]**

"Shit. How many citizens dwell in this building?"

[Twenty-Seven. Review Records?]

"No. Open Comm, request inspection and threat elimination."

[Request Complete. Urgent: Review Records] Jolt persisted.

"Fine. How bad is it?"

A list of profiles, the twenty seven intubated inhabitants, scrolled down his visor screen. Most flashed green, including B'melia. Two were red.

"Jolt! Why wasn't I alerted?"

[System Blocked. Interference Detected.]

"Interference from what? What's the cause?"

[Scanning...]

"Jolt!" The Checker became upset, pacing down to the end of the hall and back. "Just give me the rooms of the red files, I'll check on B'melia when I can." He flinched, something scurried over the floor and he span to see it.

"Replay visual."

The video of a rat running across the floor of the building replayed itself in his helmet, frame by frame. "Every time I smoke on the job, something bad happens." He said.

[Coincidence... Threat Level Assessed: Urgent Action Needed. Schematics Updated. Proceed With Caution, Checker.]

A map of the building reappeared in the Checker's visor. The schematics gave an overview of the building before zooming in and altering itself to give him a direct guide to the rooms of the threatened citizens. The Checker sipped his fortified water and got to work. Sprinting down the hall, his heavy footfalls pummeled the plasti-brick floorboards. Coming to a flight of stairs, he accelerated his mech suit and loaded the leg tension, barreling forward, he leapt. In a single leap, he shuddered in his mech suit as he touched down on the upper landing of the stairwell.

He repeated the leaping for a second flight of stairs and ran down to the first door. "I'm kicking it in."

[Protocol Approved. Proceed.]

His leg was supercharged, strength unlimited from his mech suit, but he thought twice. He tried the handle instead. The door clicked open and he walked in, heart pounding. The room was a mess. Frayed curtains covering venetian blinds, lights off, his visor adjusted to the dimness before uplinking a real time diagram of the room.

He looked at the citizen, an old woman, intubated, scraggily struggling and bed-bound.

[Condition: Damaged. Harm Assessment Initialized. Malfunction Identified.] Jolt highlighted gnawed on wires. **[Trigger Warning... Proceed?]**

"Proceed."

[Harm Assessment Complete: Rodent Feedlot Identified. Building Marked For Evacuation.]

The Checker pulled his helmet off, grunting while doing so. Buzzed hair, face unshaved, crow's feet around his darkened eyes, worry lines on his forehead, he inspected the woman. She was alive, but dying. He caught a whiff of the rot and regretted taking his helmet off, and rammed it back on his head.

"Engage air filter."

[Filtering Interior Air. You Okay Captain Chex?]

"I'm fine. She's not, though. The rats have eaten her feet. It's a wonder she's still alive. Must be a recent infestation, otherwise every sleeper in this unit would be rat food."

[They're Lucky You're Here, Checker. Notify Overseer?]

"No. Just log it onto Angel_Net, Delta would be pissed if I contacted him directly for something as insignificant as this. Just part of the job. Assign her to the medical list. Bring in the evac team and the emergency care response. Scan unit availability for relocation options."

[You Won't Like This, Checker.]

"Why?"

[Relocation Assessment Complete: Hill Home Suitability Confirmed.]

"What? Bring them home with me? Increase your search area and find all the options."

[Additional Units Discovered. Insufficient Options Require Partial Use of Hill Home.]

"How many do we have to bring back with us?"

[Hill Home Requested To Accommodate 11.3 Citizens]

"Eleven point three? Eleven point three! Where's the point three coming from Jolt? Christ, this doesn't make sense."

[Semi-Citizen Discovered.]

"What the hell is a semi-citizen, Jolt?"

[System Blocked. Interference Detected.]

"DO BETTER JOLT!"

[Yes Checker. Permit AI Assistant To Network Connection?]

"Permitted."

Jolt burrowed through the web, abandoning the Checker to discover the source of the problem. The plasti-brick units were built to prevent any and all harm that could befall a sleeper. The Checker knew something was wrong.

It would take a few moments for the backup drones to arrive. In the meantime, he had to decide between checking on B'melia or the other code red. He wanted to visit B'melia, but she would have to wait. No difference to her, yet the stupid glimmer of hope burnished his resolve.

The second code red was worse. A man, bloated, in his fifties. He had spared no expense on his bio-assist bay, opting for the exercise attachments, which had routinely developed the musculature of his arms, their density matching the robustness of his bloated gut. The real shock to the Checker wasn't his arms, however. The man's legs were missing. The exercise apparatus came complete with equipment for upper and lower body, and the mechanical stirrups meant for leg day were vacant. Stubs at the groin, the Checker examined what remained of the man's lower body. No bleeding, and he was still alive. Who had taken his legs?

No rat could eat a sleeper's leg, including the bone, and then cauterize the wound, keeping the person alive. If rats got to a sleeper, he should have been alerted. No, it had to be something else, something worse. If this one was missing his legs, in a premeditated way, done to avoid detection by Angel_Net's monitoring, well, the Checker would have to invent a protocol for this.

"Fucking hell. What's going on." He moaned.

A rattle in the hall. The Checker wanted to call Jolt, but he knew it was pointless.

He reached a hand to his back, pulling his utility bar from the magni-pak and exited the room. Adrenaline pulsed in him as he scanned the hallway. The Checker didn't see anything unusual. He sprinted to one end of the hall, glanced in both directions, doubled back to the other end, saw nothing there either. Suspicion rising, he took the next flight of stairs to B'melia's level.

"Jolt, you back yet?"

[Estimated Return: 4-7 minutes.]

The Checker paused outside B'melia's door, raising a fist to knock on it, then stopped. No need to knock, the sleepers all agreed to him checking them in their bio-assist contracts, but when it came to B'melia, he felt she deserved the respect. Sighing, he grabbed the door handle and tried to twist it open. The door stayed shut. Panicked, too much wrong had already happened today, he loaded the tension in his leg and kicked the door open.

Bursting into B'melia's studio, which should not have been locked, the Checker rushed to her bio-assist bay. Legs, arms, the rest of her, she was still there. Thinner than he remembered, but that was the norm, most people slowly lost weight while intubated, continually adjusting to a smaller and smaller life reduced them physically. Relieved, he saw that her vitals were fine.

Breathing, he sipped his fortified water and took a step back. Even without Jolt, his visor highlighted the minutest movement, coming from under B'melia's bed. The Checker bent low, getting on the floor to examine what shouldn't have been. Wires were snaking under her bio-assist bay, coiling slowly, tugged along in gentle persistence. His visor lit up, illuminating the movement of the cords. Snorting a puff of pure oxygen, the Checker reached his hand into the core of the coiling wires, felt the

squirming body of something he had yet to identify. It was wrestling with the cords while he pulled the agitated creature out from under B'melia's bio-assist bay. On his knees, crouched low, the thing fought, it grew stronger as he grappled with it. He reached at it with both hands and caught it. The Checker's grip was stronger than the creature. Powered by his mech suit, the struggling vermin had no chance of escape.

"Oh hell no."

On his knees, he had the creature in both hands. He looked at it, still wriggling in his grasp. A rat, definitely alive and mammalian in form, yet it had mechanical attachments; a spliced creature, wires coming out of nerve ports, and a jumble of robotic limbs. A spidery, distraught thing, made of rat and machine, which now grew into greater agitation. One of its attachments was doing something, bending, splitting in half, it opened and a blue flame ignited from its limb. The creature made to singe the Checker. However, his mech suit was fireproof and his will was powerful. He felt a tinge of hesitation, ignored it, and crushed the creature to death in his hands.

A sparkle of fire and smeltering smoke crackled as the rat and its tech enhancements crumpled in the Checker's hands.

[Action Restricted. Get Back To Work Checker.]

"What do you mean, Jolt?"

[Communication Pending. Continue With Task.]

He heard the clunk of droids coming through the building. The evac team was there, noisily inspecting the building, organizing their efforts at recovering the intubated citizens.

Getting up, he had to continue his exam of B'melia. "Marginal weight loss, vitals fine, VR signals sufficient, emotional state: continual ease. She's okay." He finished his assessment.

[Seven Units Available In Hill Home. Chex, You Are Required To Assist Citizens.]

"Is it seven or 11.3?"

Apologies, Checker. Miscalculation. Select Seven Citizens.

"Yeah, yeah. Let's get our seven and get out of here." He said, exiting into the hallway.

Faceless droids were busy removing doors from doorways, clearing a path for their stretchers, carefully attending to the sleepers, cautious of waking them. It had to be a strange thing for the sleepers – whatever simulated reality they were experiencing would be paused. Tranquilizers entered their systems, and every sleeper was moved from bio-assist bays to stretchers, then conveyed downstairs to be loaded into the transporter.

Three droids emerged before the stairway, blocking him.

"Agent, please move." Said a droid, before strafing out of his way.

He grabbed a droid by the shoulder, clenched it's plasti-carbon carapace with an unfriendly hand, crumpling the droid's shell.

"Just be careful with B'melia." He said before letting go.

[Authorization Admitted. Choose Your Seven Neighbors, Checker.] Jolt displayed a list of the twenty seven sleepers, from which he had to choose seven. He read their profiles as he wended down the stairs and stepped out of the building. The twenty seven sleepers were waiting, now lined up in the hall, as the protective solar shields, tent like tunnels made of collapsable panels, were extended from the front entrance of the building and connected to the transport vehicle.

He stood aside, letting the droids do their work. *Hmm.* He exhaled. "Jolt, remove the two code reds from the roster. Analyze the remaining profiles for suitability."

[Basis For Suitability, Captain Chex?]

"Based on how unlikely they are to disturb me."

[Checker's Right To Peace Respected. Select Seven From These Ten Sleepers, Checker.]

The Checker glanced over each profile, stopping at B'melia's. He selected hers, then added another six, randomly choosing them based on his unenthused impressions. It wouldn't really matter. Worst thing the sleepers would do, realistically, is suck the energy from the building, but it was free electricity, provided by Angel_Net's ubiquitous solar arrays. There was the chance that he'd get a live one, that one of these seven would experience the specific series of malfunctions that led to their return to the beige, banal, plastic coated world of 2099, and a part of him wished they'd do so, but he couldn't think like that.

[Everything Okay, Checker?]

"Yep, just double checking my selection."

[Selection Approved. Congratulations Checker, Your Neighborhood Community Has Increased.]

"Yay." Said the Checker, flatly. He mounted his wheel, soaking in the dryness of the air around him. He sipped his fortified water and rode home, battling the deflation of his spirit.

High on the causeway, leaving the abandoned, beachside downtown behind him, the view of the blank, beige city made a monotonous background, contrasting with the gradual crisis of the day's events.

[Communication Incoming. Receive Message?]

"Sure."

"Salutations, Checking Agent. This is an advance message from Overseer Delta-J9, upcoming conference scheduling now. What is your availability?" The prerecorded voice of Delta-J9 transmitted into his helmet. Several time slots popped up on his visor screen. He set his wheel to auto-drive and looked at his choices. He opted for the one farthest into the future. *Fucking J9, I have bigger problems to*

deal with right now, he kept his thoughts to himself, deciding against a verbal response to the district manager.

"Just one question Jolt."

[Ask, Checker.]

"What did you discover when you left me?"

[Apologies, Access Restricted.]

"One more question."

[Yes.]

"Will these new neighbors be a permanent installation?"

[Time Will Tell. It's Good To Make Friends In The Community, Checker.]